POLITICS THEORY OTHER

What the UK *owes* to Yemen

DR DAVID WEARING

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"Britain enabled one of the most devastating wars of the modern era. It owes Yemen reparations, not charity."

Episode of 1 October 2026 · 53 min
Report: Reparations for Yemen (CAAT & Transition Security Project, Sept 2026), with Sam Perlo-Freeman & Khem Rogaly

OBSERVATION · KEY TERM · FIGURE · QUOTATION · CROSS-LINK · 00:00 EPISODE TIME

I · The War

Origins & shape, 2011–2026 — 02:53–05:36

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The **2011 Arab uprising** topples the government, but no stable successor emerges and rival factions compete for power.

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MARCH 2015

Saudi-led intervention to restore the "internationally recognised government": recognised abroad, with a thin social base at home.

The **UAE** is the other regional power. On the ground the coalition is a disparate, unwieldy mix of government loyalists, southern separatists and militias.

7 yrs
A WAR OF ATTRITION, THEN A GRINDING STALEMATE

2022: the UAE gives up and the Saudis lose faith. A "cold peace" follows until **2026**, when Ansar Allah and Saudi Arabia escalate once more.

why Riyadh fights, why London arms

II · Britain's Role

Every practical way short of combat — 05:59–11:45

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AL-YAMAMAH · 1985

Thatcher's mega-deal for Tornado jets and Hawk trainers. More Tornados followed under Major (early 1990s), then Typhoons under New Labour (late 2000s).

A jet sale is **a relationship, not a transaction**: training jets and training, spare parts (burned through in wartime), compatible munitions and deep maintenance.

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BAE EMPLOYEES ON THE GROUND IN SAUDI ARABIA

> *"In every practical way short of engaging in combat."*
> PHILIP HAMMOND, FOREIGN SECRETARY, MARCH 2015

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British complicity runs **far deeper than in Gaza**: "nothing like" it.

British jets, Yemeni dead

III · A Man-Made Catastrophe

Why the Gaza comparison holds — 12:04–16:49

1 · BLOCKADE

An air-and-sea blockade of the region's poorest, import-dependent country. Its consequences were foreseeable: "a fair indication that you intended it."

2 · BOMBING

Ports, airports, roads and cranes; weddings, funerals, hospitals and schools. It destroyed the essential means of life.

3 · HUNGER AS WEAPON

Strikes on farms and fishing boats. Mwatana's report *Starvation Makers* found both sides used starvation as a method of warfare.

Free-fire zones in the north abolished *distinction*, a core principle of international law.

85,000
INFANTS DEAD OF STARVATION OR DISEASE IN THE EARLY YEARS (SAVE THE CHILDREN)

350–377k
TOTAL DEATHS (UNDP), AROUND HALF FROM HUNGER AND DISEASE

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CIVILIANS KILLED IN COALITION AIR RAIDS

A historic **cholera** outbreak; the UN called it "the world's worst humanitarian crisis." The Houthis also besieged enemy-held cities, but the coalition was the leading culprit.

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OF HUMAN DEVELOPMENT REVERSED (UNDP, 2019)

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IV · Britain Now

The 2026 escalation — 16:54–21:44

£464m
ARMS LICENSED TO SAUDI ARABIA, JAN–APR 2026, MOST LIKELY AIR-TO-SURFACE MISSILES

UK military **advisers**, plus an **RAF Voyager** tanker from the Burnham government for "Saudi defensive activity."

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> DEFENSIVE COVER GIVES A KNOWN WAR CRIMINAL IMPUNITY, AND MORE INCENTIVE TO STRIKE

FOUR QUESTIONS

Is "defensive only" in writing? If not, why not? How is it monitored? What happens if they don't comply?

Refuelling one sortie that hits a hospital is not "small beer." Saudi silence and no independent reporting, against **seven years of proof**.

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V · Profits & the Courts

BAE, Rolls-Royce, CAAT v. Whitehall — 21:44–28:31

BAE SYSTEMS

Prime contractor under government-to-government deals. Saudi Arabia is historically its third-largest customer.

ROLLS-ROYCE

Co-produces the Tornado and Typhoon engines, the major secondary actor.

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BAE REVENUE FROM THE SAUDI MOD, 2015–22 (≥ £2.3BN EVERY YEAR)

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WAR PROFITS: BAE £3.56BN + ROLLS-ROYCE £0.33BN

They knew from day one. Amnesty reported within a week, Amnesty and HRW within months, and UN experts by early 2016: "widespread, systematic."

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aid as debt, not gift

VI · The Reparations Plan

Justice, not charity — 28:33–33:27

STEP 1 · WINDFALL TAX

Confiscate the arms firms' war profits, an indicative **£3.9bn** from open sources. A government could calculate it precisely.

STEP 2 · STATE MATCH

Britain's state shares the guilt; it isn't in it only for arms profits. Match the £3.9bn from an aid budget restored to **0.7% of GNI**.

£7.8bn
TOTAL REPARATIONS: HUMANITARIAN RELIEF FIRST, THEN A YEMENI RECONSTRUCTION FUND

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> THE OFFHAND REMARK, A YEAR AGO, THAT BECAME THE REPORT

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UN HUMANITARIAN SHORTFALL FOR YEMEN, JANUARY 2026

In **international law**, a state that aids a wrongful act owes reparation (Mwatana and Yale, *Returned to Zero*, 2022).

Also: a **full arms embargo** on the coalition states, and on Israel and the suppliers of Sudan's RSF.

Spread it: **US activists**, then France and Germany. Use reparations as a lever for diplomacy, and set a precedent against war profiteering.

£3.9bn to confiscate

VII · Myth & Memory

A force for good? — 33:27–42:44

> *"Britain as a benign force: "a kind of national religion."*
> A BBC ONE DEBATE GUEST 'PROUD' OF UK AID TO YEMEN, AT THE HEIGHT OF THE BOMBING

Aid debates assume **munificence**. Even the "progressive" line is "be more generous," not "stop causing harm."

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Caroline Elkins's "gulag." Testimony and hidden archives forced an out-of-court settlement: small sums, but an admission.

Collective punishment keeps recurring: make the population's life hell to turn it against the rebels.

A long shot under Burnham or Miliband. Even so, the campaign puts British militarism under the microscope and builds **pressure from below**.

VIII · Sportswashing Backfires

Manchester City & the UAE — 42:44–52:48

114/115
PREMIER LEAGUE CHARGES REPORTEDLY UPHELD AGAINST UAE-OWNED MANCHESTER CITY

> *"Relegate them to Manchester League Division Five, and fine them the GDP of Abu Dhabi."*
> ONLY HALF IN JEST

Football is a vast British cultural export, **"vandalised"** by cheating. A decade of it now feels fake, and rivals were cheated of titles and Champions League places.

Gulf owners came for **hard-headed reasons**: to insulate the UK government from pressure from below.

Local investment in Manchester and Newcastle builds a domestic constituency that would resist any break with Riyadh or Abu Dhabi.

The old playbook was **quiet**: property and shareholdings kept below the ~15% that brings attention.

The spotlight cuts both ways. Even apolitical football podcasts discussed human rights during **Qatar 2022**.

> *"The biggest scandal in English football history."*
> MONARCHIES USED TO IMPUNITY AT HOME MISJUDGE INSTITUTIONS ABROAD

Mind map built from a machine transcript of the episode audio. Figures checked against the CAAT/TSP report. Timestamps refer to the episode.

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